

Should researchers feel guilty about data centres that power their AI usage?

Posted by u/Fit-Elk1425 • 0 points • 12 comments

"Australia currently has [279 data centres](<https://www.datacentermap.com/australia/>) and is becoming [one of the world's top-five data centre markets] (<https://www.climatecouncil.org.au/what-does-the-data-centre-boom-mean-for-australias-switch-to-renewables/>)— an extraordinary position for a country of its size. Australia is attractive because of its stable regulatory environment, physical location as a gateway to Asia and the Pacific, and the potential for large-scale renewable energy generation. The sector is growing fast.

Market analysis shows that data centre electricity consumption could make up 11% of Australia's demand by 2035, a huge leap from 1% today - potentially affecting electricity availability and prices for individual consumers ([CEFC 2025] (<https://www.cefc.com.au/media/media-release/data-centre-boom-to-reshape-australia-s-energy-future-cefc-baringa-report/>), [Heynes 2026](<https://www.pv-tech.org/social-backlash-inevitable-industry-demands-data-centres-stop-freeloading-on-australias-clean-energy/>)).

Australian policy appears to be keeping up with the regulatory demands of the growth in data centres that has plagued other parts of the world, such as the USA. From July 2025, all data centres hosting federal government workloads are required to achieve a minimum five-star NABERS rating under the [Net Zero in Government Operations Strategy] (https://www.finance.gov.au/sites/default/files/2023-11/Net_Zero_Government_Operations_Strategy.pdf). Late last year, the Australian Government launched the [National AI Plan] (<https://www.industry.gov.au/publications/national-ai-plan/national-ai-plan-page>) and, just this week, released a policy that articulates [expectations of data centres for their license to operate in Australia](<https://www.industry.gov.au/publications/expectations-data-centres-and-ai-infrastructure-developers>). These expectations require data centre projects to demonstrate "benefit to the Australian economy, people and their local communities" to receive priority for approval or investment.

This policy expects data centre projects to support Australia's energy transition (eg data centres should not place upward pressure on energy prices, should minimise energy demand, and use clean energy where available); minimise water usage (eg mitigate impacts of water disruptions, drought and climate change, use secure, non-potable water); create fair, safe, secure and well-paid jobs for Australian workers; and support research and

innovation across all sectors at favourable terms. Further, in NSW, an ongoing [parliamentary enquiry into data centres] (<https://www.parliament.nsw.gov.au/lcdocs/inquiries/3169/Terms%20of%20reference%20-%20PAWC%20-%20Data%20centres%20-%20updated%205%20February%202026.pdf>) will help governments and communities to set operating rules for how data centre projects should be considered in light of environmental factors, planning frameworks, electricity demand, community impacts, housing availability, workforce considerations, and economic and distributional outcomes.

Although criticisms have been levelled at data centres from a range of climate-concerned organisations, these same organisations agreed that “**handled wisely, \[Australia’s\] new demand could become a powerful driver for renewable energy investment. Data centres could anchor new solar, wind and battery projects, financing firming capacity and supporting regional economic development”** ([Climate Council 2025] (<https://www.climatecouncil.org.au/what-does-the-data-centre-boom-mean-for-australias-switch-to-renewables/>)). Data centres have the potential to accelerate and anchor critical, renewable energy transitions

Comments

u/mrdarknezz1 • 1 points • 2026-03-29 19:56 UTC

No

u/bunker_man • 2 points • 2026-03-29 18:50 UTC

No.

u/Bulky-Employer-1191 • 6 points • 2026-03-29 17:49 UTC

Should you feel guilty about doing anything online? Playing games? Using any energy at all?

Of course the answer is no.

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 0 points • 2026-03-29 23:03 UTC

This is something this paper helps to point out

u/phase_distorter41 • 9 points • 2026-03-29 16:50 UTC

>Should researchers feel guilty about data centres that power their AI usage?

no

u/Fit-Elk1425 • -1 points • 2026-03-29 17:00 UTC

To be fair i just kept the default title and more hoped people would read the article for its interesting piece on australia case study

u/MakeDawn • 3 points • 2026-03-29 17:10 UTC

Dawg. No one here wants to read. We're all addicted to being rage baited and flamed.

[https://preview.redd.it/2n5m9u14o0sg1.jpeg?](https://preview.redd.it/2n5m9u14o0sg1.jpeg?width=640&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=d53bce44d9b2bffc30bd850faa6fd9efdb202f3)

[width=640&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=d53bce44d9b2bffc30bd850faa6fd9efdb202f3](https://preview.redd.it/2n5m9u14o0sg1.jpeg?width=640&format=pjpg&auto=webp&s=d53bce44d9b2bffc30bd850faa6fd9efdb202f3)

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 2 points • 2026-03-29 17:31 UTC

Because maybe it will at least be a distraction for someone or they will be ragebaited into reading the whole thing

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 2 points • 2026-03-29 17:30 UTC

I know but i try

u/phase_distorter41 • 2 points • 2026-03-29 17:10 UTC

post a link to the article and then your own thoughts on it. other wise its just low effort post and gets low effort replies.

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 1 points • 2026-03-29 17:29 UTC

But good advice, just always hard to pick a title

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 1 points • 2026-03-29 17:29 UTC

That is why i included and focused on that section specifically